NATURAL STATE OF AFFAIRS



CHEW THE CUD Desi cows are bred at a natural farming homestead near Tirumala

Andhra Pradesh has been a frontrunner in implementing Natural Farming (NF) on a mass scale. The state government initiated the Zero Budget Natural Farming (ZBNM) initiative in 2016. "The Andhra Pradesh Community Managed Natural Farming (APCNF) initiative [ZBNM has since been renamed]has got 630,000 farmers promoting NF, making it the largest such programme in the world," claims T. Vijay Kumar, executive vice-chairperson of Rythu Sadhikara Samastha (RySS). It has identified champion NF farmers as community resource persons (CRPs) to act as mentors to the new converts.

NF follows traditional organic farming practices based on local resources, botanical extracts (such as neem for pest control) and indigenous seeds. "RySS has used farmer-to-farmer experiential knowledge as a means to empower 8,000 CRPs across the state," says Vijay Kumar. Each CRP is expected to work with 100 farmers.

In 2021-22, the APCNF programme had some 288,000 ha. under cultivation. In addition, 190,000 poor households have raised NF-based kitchen gardens in their homes. In 2022-23, the NF effort is expected to cover 1.06 million farmers who will be cultivating 458,000 hectares in the state.

In 2020, the state took a Rs 783 crore (90 million euros) soft loan from KfW Bank, Germany, to set up an exclusive NF department for the project. Azim Premji Philanthropic Initiatives also supports the NF programme with a Rs 100 crore grant for technical backstopping.

A study by the Institute for Development Studies, AP, says NF has reduced the costs (though yields remain the same) of farmers. It also says practitioners had a higher net income of Rs 25,000 per ha. compared to farmers relying on conventional agriculture. Andhra has emerged as a resource centre and is supporting states like Rajasthan, Bihar, Odisha, Meghalaya and Kerala on NF practices too.



BULL RUN
CM Jagan Reddy inaugurates the Sri Venkateswara Go Saptha Go Pradakshina Mandiram, Oct. 2021

around Rs 100 crore as donations in addition to the cows that have arrived as gifts. This has helped the transition and, for over a year now, everything used as offerings to the deity has been made out of cow products. Even the paddy used in rituals comes from organic fields where the only manure used is cow dung and urine.

It's been a year since the launch of the Navaneeta Scheme, and the TTD has converted its 450-acre gaushala at Palamaner in Chittoor district into a research hub. An MoU has been signed with the S.V. Veterinary University, Tirupati, and NuTech Biosciences Pvt Ltd to commission a feed mixing plant for the bovines by January 2023. "We'll have a campaign to educate farmers about cow-based *panchagavvya* products that could become a profitable enterprise for them," says K.S. Jawahar Reddy, special chief secretary to the Andhra Pradesh chief minister and a veterinary science graduate himself. "Popularising indigenous bovines is a watershed project and the TTD will shift 1,000 such bulls and cows from the dairy farm to the *gaushala*," says Reddy, who is an ex-TTD executive officer.

The TTD is also partnering the S.V. Veterinary University and a private entity, Tropical Animal Genetics, to establish an embryo transfer technology laboratory to produce indigenous cow embryos of high yielding varieties. "This will be a launchpad for TTD to produce high-yielding indigenous cows and create a genetic pool of the same for the nation. The lab will be a centre for excellence for indigenous milch cows," says Reddy.

In October 2021, the TTD also joined hands with the Andhra Pradesh Rythu Sadhikara Samithi (RySS), a state organisation that works with women self-help groups (SHGs). The common mandate is to encourage organic farming in the fields from where the Natural Farming (NF) produce required for the Tirumala temple and the string of TTD institutions is procured. The RySS identified the